

First-Week Onboarding Checklist

This checklist translates the onboarding model into concrete, trackable actions for the period before day one through the end of the first week.

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1.0 Purpose

The checklist exists to turn onboarding from a loose set of good intentions into an operational workflow with visible ownership. It helps new hires, managers, People Operations, and IT complete required tasks in the right order so the employee's first week is productive rather than consumed by avoidable setup delays.

For a production-level RAG dataset, the checklist needs enough operational depth to answer questions like what should happen before day one, who is responsible for access readiness, and how missing tasks are escalated when the standard timeline breaks down.

2.0 Scope

This checklist applies to all new hires and the support teams involved in their onboarding. Department leaders may add role-specific tasks, but the baseline company checklist should still be completed because it controls the core administrative and operational handoff.

The document covers pre-start preparation, day-one activities, days-two-through-five tasks, and the manager review that closes the first week. It is intended to be executed alongside the broader new employee guide, not in place of it.

- Covers People Operations, IT, manager, onboarding buddy, and new-hire responsibilities.
- Applies whether onboarding occurs remotely, on-site, or in a hybrid format.
- Requires visible ownership for incomplete or blocked tasks by the end of the first week.

3.0 Responsibilities

The responsibilities below define who must act, approve, review, and maintain records so the process can be executed consistently across teams and audit periods.

3.1 New Hires

- Complete assigned tasks, confirm access, and raise blockers through the shared onboarding tracker.
- Review provided guides, complete required forms, and attend scheduled orientation sessions.
- Document unclear instructions rather than bypassing the process with informal workarounds.

3.2 Managers

- Confirm the 30-day plan, align meetings, and ensure the role-specific onboarding path is ready.
- Review checklist completion during day-one and end-of-week check-ins.
- Assign owners for missing tasks rather than allowing open issues to remain untracked.

3.3 People Operations and IT

- Prepare HR, payroll, identity, device, and access prerequisites before the employee starts.
- Maintain the checklist system, respond to issues within service targets, and route unresolved items correctly.
- Provide evidence of completion for tasks that affect payroll, compliance, or security.

4.0 Pre-Start Preparation

A strong first week begins before the employee's first day. Managers, People Operations, and IT should confirm role details, required systems, equipment logistics, payroll setup, and onboarding sessions in advance so the new hire is not forced to spend the first day chasing avoidable administrative issues.

Preparation tasks should be tracked in a shared system with due dates and owners. If a laptop, account, or signed document is missing, the issue should be visible before the start date rather than discovered after orientation begins.

- Confirm job title, reporting line, location, manager, and start-date details.
- Prepare equipment, identity records, baseline applications, and payroll setup.
- Send welcome communications with orientation schedule, contact points, and day-one instructions.

5.0 Day-One Execution

Day one should validate that the onboarding plan actually worked. The new hire must be able to access primary systems, understand immediate expectations, and identify where documents, support channels, and upcoming tasks are located. The manager should not assume orientation alone creates clarity.

The checklist should be used actively during the day-one check-in so unresolved items become explicit actions with owners. This reduces the risk that access gaps or ambiguous instructions linger unaddressed until they slow down the first real assignment.

5.1 New Hire Day-One Tasks

- Log into email, calendar, chat, HRIS, password manager, and any required team workspace.
- Verify emergency contact, tax, payroll, and identity details in the HR system.
- Review orientation content and note any missing access or unclear instructions immediately.

5.2 Manager Day-One Tasks

- Hold a welcome meeting and explain how work is assigned, tracked, and reviewed.
- Review meeting cadence, team communication expectations, and escalation routes.
- Introduce the new hire to the buddy and key cross-functional contacts needed in the first month.

6.0 Days Two Through Five and End-of-Week Review

The rest of the first week should combine structured learning with early execution. The employee should read role-relevant policies, join recurring team rituals, shadow at least one live workflow, and begin contributing through a scoped task that builds confidence without creating unnecessary risk.

The end-of-week review closes the operational loop. The manager and new hire should identify what was completed, what remains blocked, and what needs to happen in week two. Open items should be assigned owners and dates rather than being carried forward as informal assumptions.

- Complete required compliance, privacy, security, and workplace training.
- Read the department handbook, current roadmap, and role-specific SOPs or runbooks.
- Attend recurring meetings and document unresolved onboarding blockers in the shared tracker.
- Review week-one completion status and assign owners for any incomplete tasks.

7.0 Exceptions and Escalation

If day-one or first-week tasks cannot be completed, the exception must be documented with an owner, due date, and business impact. Exceptions matter most when they affect compliance training, payroll setup, identity verification, or access to tools needed for the employee's role.

Escalate to People Operations or IT immediately when the missing task affects pay, security controls, required legal documentation, or the employee's ability to begin assigned work safely and correctly.

8.0 Records and Review

Checklist completion status, timestamps, and evidence for key administrative tasks should be retained in the onboarding tracker or HR system. Managers should use the tracker during review conversations instead of relying on memory.

The checklist is reviewed each quarter using support metrics, manager feedback, and new-hire survey themes. Repeated blockers should trigger updates to upstream provisioning or communication processes rather than ad hoc

local fixes.